

Sijia “Leslie” Huang

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201 Mullica Hill Road, Glassboro, New Jersey 08028

EDUCATION

Rowan University

Glassboro, NJ

Doctor of Philosophy in Clinical Psychology (APA accredited, emphasis on integrated healthcare and health psychology)
Expected Graduation: May 2029

Advisors: D.J. Angelone, Ph.D. and Meredith Jones, Ph.D.

Columbia University, Teachers College

New York, NY

Master of Arts in Psychology in Education: General Psychology
May 2024

New York University Shanghai

Shanghai, China | New York, NY

Bachelor of Arts in Social Science (Psychology Track)
May 2022
Minor in Humanities

HONORS & AWARDS

Rowan University Outstanding Pre-Candidate Clinical Doctoral Student Award	2026
Rowan University Graduate Student Travel Fund (\$600)	2024
Columbia University Teachers College Scholarship (\$3,000)	2022 – 2023
NYU Shanghai Global Elite Scholar (¥120,000, approx. \$17,850)	2018 – 2022
Dean’s List for Academic Years, NYU Shanghai	2020 – 2022
Deans’ Undergraduate Research Funds at NYU Shanghai (\$1,000)	2021

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

1. **Huang, S.**, Yang, J., & Santtila, P. (2025). After the Act: After-Sex Behaviors and Their Correlates in Straight Chinese Couples. *Sexes*, 6(3), 48. <https://doi.org/10.3390/sexes6030048>
2. Li, Z., **Huang, S.**, & Santtila, P. (2025). Sexual communication in Chinese heterosexual couples: the efficacy of online Sensate Focus intervention and correlations with relational and sexual outcomes. *Sexual and Relationship Therapy*, 1–29. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14681994.2025.2506090>
3. **Huang, S.**, Wang, Y., Li, G., Hall, B.J., & Nyman, T.J. (2024). Digital Mental Health Interventions for Alleviating Depression and Anxiety During Psychotherapy Waiting Lists: Systematic Review. *JMIR: Mental Health*. 2024;11:e56650 doi: [10.2196/56650](https://doi.org/10.2196/56650) PMID: [39255015](https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/39255015/).
4. **Huang, S.**, Li, Z., & Santtila, P. (2024). The effectiveness of online sensate focus exercises in enhancing sexual function and intimacy among Chinese heterosexual couples: a randomized controlled trial. *Journal of Sex & Marital Therapy*, 50(6), 707–724. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0092623X.2024.2355229>.
5. Eschliman, E. L., Hoang, D., Khoshnam, N., Ye, V., Kokaze, H., Ji, Y., Zhong, Y., Morumganti, A., Xi, W., **Huang, S.**, Choe, K., Poku, O. B., Alvarez, G., Nguyen, T., Nguyen, N. T., Shelley, D., & Yang, L. H. (2024). A “What Matters Most” approach to investigating intersectional stigma toward HIV and cancer in Hanoi, Vietnam. *Journal of the National Cancer Institute Monographs*, 2024(63), 11–19. <https://doi.org/10.1093/jncimonographs/lgae002>.

6. **Huang, S.**, Nyman, T.J., Jern, P., & Santtila, P. (2023). Actual and desired masturbation frequency, sexual distress and their correlates. *Archives of Sexual Behavior* 52, 3155–3170. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10508-023-02641-3>.
7. **Huang, S.**, Jern, P., Niu, C., & Santtila, P. (2023). Associations between sexually submissive and dominant behaviors and sexual function in men and women. *International Journal of Impotence Research*, 37, 224–232. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41443-023-00705-5>.
8. **Huang, S.**, Niu, C., & Santtila, P. (2022). Masturbation frequency and sexual function in individuals with and without sexual partners. *Sexes* 3, 229–243. <https://doi.org/10.3390/sexes3020018>.

MANUSCRIPTS UNDER REVIEW AND IN PREPARATION

1. **Huang, S.**, Santtila, P., Angelone, D.J., & Jones, M. C. [Under review] Online Sexual Interventions in Enriching Couple's Sex Life: A Narrative Review.
2. **Huang, S.**, Jones, M. C., Angelone, D.J., Jern, P., & Brunwasser, S. M. [Under review] Sexual dysfunction as a predictor of sexual violence perpetration among Finnish men and women.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

1. Angelone, D.J., Mitchell, D., Wells, B.E., Korovich, M., Bettinelli, M., **Huang, S.**, & Shirley, J. (2025, Nov. 14). *Examining factors influencing sexual violence risk perception in men who have sex with men on dating and sexual networking Apps*. Symposium presented at the annual conference of the Society for the Scientific Study of Sexuality; Philadelphia, PA. [CE credit]
2. **Huang, S.**, Korovich, M., Angelone, D.J., Mitchell, D., & Wells, B.E. (2025, Nov. 14). *Associations between sexual self-esteem, dating motives, and risk perception*. Paper presented at the annual conference of the Society for the Scientific Study of Sexuality; Philadelphia, PA.
3. **Huang, S.**, Shank, F., Korovich, M., Arigo, D., Jones, M., & Angelone, D.J. (2024, Nov. 16). *Associations between college sexual hookup behavior and eating disorders*. Poster presented at the annual conference of the Society for the Scientific Study of Sexuality; San Diego, CA.
4. Li, B., **Huang, S.**, Daneils, L., Cai, B., Phillips M., & Yang, L.H. (2024, Aug. 8). *Demographic and clinical characteristics of Chinese schizophrenia patients assessed by MCCB*. Poster presented at the 2024 American Psychological Association Conference, Division 40 – Society for Clinical Neuropsychology. Seattle, USA.
5. **Huang, S.** & Santtila, P. (2023, Aug. 8). *The effectiveness of online sensate focus exercises in enhancing sexual function and intimacy among Chinese heterosexual couples*. Poster presented at the 49th annual conference of the International Academy of Sex Research; Montreal, Canada.
6. **Huang, S.** & Santtila, P. (2023, Apr. 28). *Can online sensate focus exercises enhance sexual and relationship satisfaction among Chinese heterosexual couples?* Poster presented at the 6th annual conference of the Institute of Psychological Science and Practice at Columbia University Teachers College. New York, USA. Awarded for Outstanding Poster.
7. **Huang, S.** & Santtila, P. (2021, Nov. 6). *How does sexual dysfunction relate to relationship and sexual satisfaction among Chinese adults?* Poster presented at Fall 2021 Undergraduate Research Symposium. NYU Shanghai, China. Awarded for Best Research Project in Liberal Arts & Business.

8. **Huang, S. & Santtila, P.** (2020, Dec. 14). *How Do Chinese Parents Perceive Sex Education Program at Elementary Schools?* Poster presented at Fall 2020 Empirical Research Practice Symposium. NYU Shanghai, China.

Clinical Experience

Practicum Extern at Cooper University Hospital

Camden, NJ

Integrated Ambulatory Care (Outpatient Rotation)

in the Center for Comprehensive Health (Supervisor: Michael DeAngelo, Psy.D.) Jul 2025 – Present

- Provide outpatient psychotherapy to patients with HIV or other chronic infectious diseases, presenting depression, anxiety, trauma-related symptoms, insomnia, behavioral and/or substance use problems.
- Utilize evidence-based treatments, including cognitive behavioral therapy, mindfulness, trauma-informed approaches, and motivation interviewing.
- Conduct initial clinical interview and neurocognitive and psychodiagnostic assessments.
- Assist inpatient consult for newly admitted patients who are HIV+ to cope with hospitalization.
- Participate in weekly behavioral medicine didactics, case presentation, and group supervision.
- Attend multidisciplinary treatment team meetings with physicians, nurses, case management, and navigation to collaborate on patient care.

Student Counselor for Cognitive Processing Therapy (CPT), NYU Shanghai

Shanghai, China

(PI: Dr. Gu Li)

Feb 2023 – Feb 2025

- Provide online feedback for Chinese gay men who are going through adapted CPT intervention, under the supervision of licensed psychologist Dr. Thomas Nyman.
- Code the accuracy of self-identified maladaptive thoughts and propose thought-challenging questions.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

ASSeRT Lab, Rowan University

Glassboro, NJ

PhD Student (PI: D.J. Angelone, Ph.D. and Meredith Jones, Ph.D.)

Aug 2024 – Present

Lab website: <https://www.rowanassert.com/>.

Sexual Dysfunction and Sexual Violence Perpetration Study

- Conduct research on sexual dysfunction, trait anger, and sexual violence perpetration.
- Successfully defended thesis titled “Sexual Dysfunction as a Predictor of Sexual Violence Perpetration among Finnish Men and Women” on October 22 2025, for Masters of Arts in Clinical Psychology.

Intoxication and Aggression Study

- Assist The Manhattan Project, investigating the impact of alcohol intoxication on male aggression in laboratory paradigms.

Barriers of Engaging in Healthcare among Young Moms

- Lead a qualitative study about young moms’ experiences in healthcare, code interview transcripts, identify themes, and conduct thematic analysis.
- Mentor a coding team of 5 students.

Mentor Experience

- Mentor 4 undergraduate students and provide training in literature review, article presentation, participants recruitment, and data cleaning using syntax in SPSS.

Sex Research, NYU Shanghai

Shanghai, China

Co-Investigator (PI: Pekka Santtila, Ph.D.)

Oct 2020 – Aug 2024

Sensate Focus Sex Therapy Study

- Completed IRB application, including a Randomized Control Trial study protocol, subsequent amendments, and annual reports.
- Developed 11 animation videos demoing Sensate Focus Exercises, based on the sex therapy model proposed by Masters and Johnson.
- Pre-screened 1,231 Chinese participants for Sensate Focus intervention through three waves, assessing sexual dysfunction, relationship and sexual satisfaction, and sexual script.
- Facilitated the longitudinal experimental intervention, post-test, and three months follow-up assessments with 19 couples in the experimental group, 24 couples in the waitlist control group.
- Employ various statistical analyses in SPSS and R, including syntax, Pearson Correlation, Independent-Sample *t*-test, Paired-Sample *t*-test, Cronbach's alphas Reliability test, ANOVA, ANCOVA, Repeated Measures, and Linear Mixed-effects Model.

Masturbation, Sexual Distress, and Sexual Function Study

- Analyzed data on masturbation frequency and related sexual distress from a Finnish population-based datafile, including 12,271 participants that Dr. Santtila previously collected.
- Explored the correlated factors and etiology of sexual distress.
- Conducted statistical analyses in SPSS, including Chi-square, Linear Regression, and General Estimated Equations.
- Discussed implications of clinical diagnosis of compulsive sexual behavior, particularly problematic masturbation.

Paraphilia and Sexual Dysfunction Study

- Investigated the association between paraphilia, especially BDSM interest and related behavior, and sexual function among Finnish people.
- Combined and analyzed three data sets that Dr. Santtila and his colleagues previously collected, with 29,821 participants in total.

Sex Education in China Study

- Investigated Chinese parents' attitudes towards sex education, focusing on parents with children in elementary schools.
- Designed an online survey using Qualtrics and recruited 182 participants.
- Analyzed the correlation between parents' overall supportiveness of sex education and delivery method, specific teaching contents, and other statements about sex education.
- Performed in Professor Santtila's weekly research seminar from 2021 to 2022, collaborated with ECNU graduate student working on sex research, engaging in discussions covering a wide range of topics, including early ejaculation, ginger's impact on sex drive, obesity and sexuality, internalized homophobia, and the interplay between sexual arousal and the feeling of disgust.

Maternal and Reproductive Psychology Lab, Columbia University

Research Assistant (PI: Aurelie Athan, Ph.D.)

New York, NY

Feb 2024 – Jul 2024

- Completed training in Sex Education Initiative
- Assisted qualitative analysis about Reproductive Life Planning

Digital Mental Health, NYU Shanghai

Research Assistant (PI: Thomas Nyman, Ph.D.)

Shanghai, China

May 2023 – May 2024

- Conducted literature review on the effectiveness of digital intervention for people waiting for face-to-face therapy.
- Performed articles searching in PubMed, PsycINFO, Cochrane, and Web of Science.
- Developed study protocol and completed pre-registration in OSF.

- Completed abstract and title screening for 9267 articles using Covidence.
- Assisted full-text review for 23 articles and conducted data extraction.

Loss, Trauma, and Resilience Lab, Columbia University

New York, NY

Research Assistant (PI: George Bonanno, Ph.D.)

Feb 2023 – May 2024

- Investigated coping mechanisms in response to challenging life experiences, with a specific focus on individuals who engage in nonsuicidal self-injurious (NSSI) behaviors and those who do not.
- Managed the study email inbox and coordinated participants scheduling on a weekly basis.
- Assisted pre-data processing, including stamping, editing, and transcribing of the recorded interviews with the participants.

Culture, Stigma, and Psychosis Lab, Columbia University

New York, NY

Research Assistant (PI: Lawrence Yang, Ph.D.)

Oct 2022 – May 2024

Psychosis in China Study

- Conducted research on cognition across the lifespan in untreated psychosis in China.
- Reviewed 61 articles about MATRICS Consensus Cognitive Battery (MCCB), 45 in Chinese and 16 in English.
- Extracted data on 79 columns for each article.
- Assisted data cleaning and data extraction training for new research assistants.
- Led poster preparation for 2024 APA Conference, entitled “Demographic and clinical characteristics of Chinese schizophrenia patients assessed by MCCB.”
- Assisted in compilation of grant proposals via conducting literature reviews on the association between antipsychotic medications and accelerated aging, as well as mediators of cognitive deficits in schizophrenia.

Cancer, HIV, and Mental Health in Vietnam Study

- Examined stigma of cancer, HIV, and mental health in people living with HIV in Vietnam.
- Coded related qualitative data (i.e., interviews) based on the codebook.
- Assisted scale development for interview transcripts, discussed with others to come up with scale items based on the key qualitative themes, identified relevant quotes in the interviews.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor, College of Science and Mathematics at Rowan University

- Psychology of Human Sexuality Spring 2026
- Essentials of Psychology Fall 2025

Learning Assistant, College of Science and Mathematics at Rowan University

- Physiological Psychology Spring 2025
- Abnormal Psychology Fall 2024

MEDIA COVERAGE

1. **PsyPost**, Feb 2025, “Low user engagement limits effectiveness of digital mental health interventions.” <https://www.psypost.org/low-user-engagement-limits-effectiveness-of-digital-mental-health-interventions/>
2. **NYU Shanghai Center for Global Health Equity**, Nov 2024, “New Review Reveals Limited Effectiveness of Digital Mental Health Interventions for Individuals Awaiting Psychotherapy.”

<https://cghe.shanghai.nyu.edu/news/new-review-reveals-limited-effectiveness-digital-mental-health-interventions-individuals>

3. **PsyPost**, Nov 2023, “Study uncovers subtle links between BDSM practices and sexual well-being.” <https://www.psypost.org/study-uncovers-subtle-links-between-bdsm-practices-and-sexual-well-being/>
4. **PsyPost**, Oct 2023, “Large study unpacks the complicated nature of ‘problematic masturbation.’” <https://www.psypost.org/large-study-unpacks-the-complicated-nature-of-problematic-masturbation/>

LEADERSHIP & SERVICE

Student Involvement Co-Chair, *Board of Directors at the Society for the Scientific Study of Sexuality* Nov 2025 – Present

- Serve as the representative for student members within the organization and plan events to foster engagement, professional development, and increase networking opportunities.
- Attend board of directors’ meetings throughout the year to discuss committee ideas and advocate for student member needs.
- Plan and organize the annual scientific conference meeting, including special events exclusive for the student members.

Lab Coordinator, *ASSeRT Lab at Rowan University* Nov 2025 – Present

- Oversee day-to-day operations of the ASSeRT lab, including project management, data organization, and communication across 2 faculty, 5 doctoral students, 15 undergraduate students, and 2 post baccalaureate volunteers.
- Track all current research projects to maintain productivity, preserve project timelines, and facilitate clear communication across all researchers.
- Lead weekly leadership and lab meetings to meet research goals, track progress, designate tasks, and problem-solve any issues that arise.
- Coordinate research assistant recruitment and onboarding, including application review, interviewing, and intradepartmental communication.
- Manage administrative documentation and training materials to standardize lab procedures and improve research efficiency.

Orientation Ambassador, *Office of Student Life at NYU Shanghai* Apr 2021 – Oct 2021

- Served as a peer mentor for a group of 17 NYU Shanghai freshmen from 6 different countries.
- Hosted an informative session titled “Let’s Talk about Sex | Sexual Misconduct.”
- Facilitated 7 diversity and inclusivity dialogues for the group to foster a healthy community, discussing topics such as food, language, socializing, and resilience.
- Provided advice on life, academic, and career planning, supporting freshmen in transitioning smoothly to life at NYU Shanghai.

Student Worker, *Student Health Center at NYU Shanghai* Oct 2018 – May 2019

- Created articles about health and wellness using online platform Xiumi for WeChat Official Accounts, reaching an average of 200 out of 1200 viewers in the NYU Shanghai community.
- Designed weekly newsletter emails for the NYU Shanghai community using Mailchimp.
- Promoted lectures, events, workshops, and activities about health to encourage healthy lifestyles within the NYU community.

EDITORIAL EXPERIENCES

Peer Review for Academic Journals

- *Discover Social Science and Health*: 1 review in 2026
- *Journal of Sex & Marital Therapy*: 1 review in 2024; 4 review in 2025
- *Psychology, Health & Medicine*: 1 review in 2025
- *Nature Partner Journals (NPJ) Women's Health*: 1 review in 2024
- *BMC Psychiatry*: 1 review in 2024
- *BMC Women's Health*: 1 review in 2024

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

The Society for the Scientific Study of Sexuality	Jul 2024 – Present
American Psychological Association	Sep 2023 – Present
Psi Chi, The International Honor Society in Psychology	Feb 2023 – Present
International Academy of Sex Research	Jan 2023 – Present
American Association of Sexuality Educators, Counselors and Therapist	Jan 2023 – Present

GRANT APPLICATIONS

[External] The Society for the Scientific Study of Sexuality: Graduate Student Research Grant

Mar 2026

Relationship Enrichment: The Feasibility and Acceptability of an Online Couples' Program Using Sensate Focus Sex Therapy

PI: Sijia Huang, M.A.

Faculty Mentors: Meredith Jones, Ph.D., and D.J. Angelone, Ph.D.

Amount Requested: \$1,500

Status: Under review

[External] Society for Health Psychology: Graduate Student Research Awards

Jan 2026

Digital Sensate Focus: Evaluating an Animation-Based Sex Therapy Program

PI: Sijia Huang, M.A.

Faculty Mentors: Meredith Jones, Ph.D., and D.J. Angelone, Ph.D.

Amount Requested: \$2,000

Status: Under review

[Internal] Columbia University Teachers College Dean's Grant for Student Research

Nov 2022

Can Web-based Sensate Focus Exercises Enhance Sexual and Relationship Satisfaction?

PI: Sijia Huang, B.A.

Faculty Mentor: Pekka Santtila, Ph.D.

Amount Requested: \$2,000

Status: Not funded

[Internal] NYU Shanghai Deans' Undergraduate Research Funds

May 2021

Can Web-based Sensate Focus Exercises Enhance Relationship Satisfaction?

PI: Sijia Huang

Faculty Mentor: Pekka Santtila, Ph.D.

Amount Requested: \$1,000

Status: Funded

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

Sex Education Initiative at Teachers College	Feb 2024 – Mar 2024
Social Emotional Learning at ThinkHuman.TV	Sep 2023 – Dec 2023
Yale Psychology's Sneak Peek Program	Jul 2023 – May 2024
NextGen Psych Scholars Program (NPSP) at University of Minnesota	Jun 2023 – May 2024

SKILLS

Language: English (fluent), Mandarin Chinese (native), Sichuanese (native)

Data Analysis and Online Methods: R, SPSS, Eye-tracking (TOBII, Gazepoint, ELAN), Qualtrics, EndNote, Zotero, Covidence, Web design using Github and Squarespace